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SWENG 805: Software Project Management

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Portfolio Entry 9: Reflections

Over the duration of this class, I've learned not only about the methodology of project management, but I've also learned a lot about myself, my strengths, weaknesses, and the areas that I need to focus on improving in order to be successful as a Project Manager in the future. This course allowed me to reflect on how I currently approach leadership, negotiation, estimation, and team-based activities and realize that I do have some strengths in these skills, however, there are definitely areas where I need further development in order to maximize my potential as a Project Manager.

First, I learned about my understanding of the project manager's role and how it relates to my personality and work style. A Project Manager is responsible for managing all aspects of a project. A project manager is responsible for planning, organizing, estimating, communication, and activities that ensure that the project meets its deadlines on time, within budget, and with a high-quality end product. It was through this course that I realized that I am very organized and task-oriented, which helps me break projects down into smaller pieces to help me complete them more efficiently. My organized and task-oriented style fits well within a structured management style, as I like to know what to expect and have clear goals of what needs to be completed. However, I also learned that I tend to focus too much on completing tasks than on motivating

and developing the people I work with, that I like to work more by myself rather than as a team, and that's not a good characteristic for just a Project Manager but also a team member in general. This realization showed me that while I possess strengths in organization and planning, I need to focus on developing my leadership presence, so I can support those people who report to me, and inspire them, in addition to just managing their work.

One of the most important lessons I learned in this course was the difference between being a manager and being a leader. Managers focus on planning, organizing, and maintaining efficiency, while leaders focus more on setting direction, motivating people, and helping the team succeed. I learned about several leadership styles, including transformational, transactional, charismatic, servant, ideological, and pragmatic leadership. Based on my personality, I believe I currently lean more toward transactional leadership because I focus on structure, clear expectations, and rewarding good performance, but also poor performances will suffer consequences. I like having clear deadlines and making sure tasks are completed properly. However, I also learned that this leadership style alone is not enough. To become a better leader, I need to develop more transformational and charismatic qualities, such as encouraging my team, supporting them, and helping them feel more connected to the project. My goal is to become a balanced leader who can both manage the work effectively and motivate the team to do their best.

This course also helped me recognize antipatterns that I have experienced in past teams and how I may have allowed them to happen. One example is the Ultimate Weapon antipattern, where one person becomes responsible for the most important parts of the project because they are the most experienced. While this can help in the short term, it creates problems if that person

leaves because no one else has the same knowledge. I have also experienced Kiosk City, where knowledge is not shared and is instead held by certain individuals. Looking back, I realize that I contributed to this problem by relying too much on the most experienced person instead of making sure everyone understood the system. In the future, I will work to prevent these antipatterns by encouraging teamwork, sharing knowledge, and making sure important information is documented. This will help make the team more stable and reduce risk.

Self-examination has been important for me as it pertains to negotiation skills. My evaluation of my negotiation strengths and weaknesses indicates that my strongest power is legitimate power, meaning others listen to me because of my role or title. However, my lowest rated power was charismatic power, meaning how well I influence and inspire others. This shows that while others may respect my position, they do not always feel that I am motivating them. Working on my confidence in public speaking, improving my communication skills, and supporting others as a leader will help me to become a negotiator for win-win solutions based on collaboration and trust, and not simply through the use of positional power and authority.

This course also helped me understand the causes of schedule failure and how to prevent them. I learned that schedule failure happens because of poor estimation, unrealistic deadlines, lack of planning, scope creep, and poor communication. I realized that in my own programming projects, I sometimes underestimated how long certain tasks would take, which caused stress and forced me to rush at the end. I learned that better estimation requires breaking projects into smaller tasks, using past experiences as a reference, and including extra time for unexpected problems such as bugs. In the future, I will use these techniques to make more accurate estimates and avoid schedule failure.

I also learned how to better understand the cost and effort involved in my work. I have used analogy-based estimation in my programming assignments by comparing new projects to ones I completed before and using that experience to estimate how long tasks would take. This helped me understand that experience plays a major role in making accurate estimates. As I continue gaining experience, I believe my estimation skills will improve, which will help me become a more effective project manager.

Another important concept I learned was systemic thinking, which means understanding how different parts of a project are connected and how problems in one area can affect everything else. I learned that projects are not just about individual tasks, but about people, communication, and teamwork working together as a system. For example, poor communication can cause delays, confusion, and mistakes across the entire project. This helped me realize that as a project manager, I need to think about the bigger picture and understand how my decisions affect the team and the project as a whole. By improving communication and teamwork, I can help improve the overall success of the project and the organization.

Overall, this course helped me better understand myself, including my strengths and weaknesses. My strengths include being organized, structured, and able to plan tasks effectively. My weaknesses include needing to improve my ability to motivate others, communicate more confidently, and develop stronger leadership influence. By recognizing these areas, I now understand what I need to work on to improve myself. Ultimately, this course helped me grow both professionally and personally. I now have a better understanding of what it takes to be a successful project manager and what I need to do to improve. By continuing to develop my

leadership, negotiation, estimation, and communication skills, I can become an effective project manager in the future.

Action Plan for My Development/Improvement

1. To improve myself, I will work on becoming a stronger leader by supporting and encouraging my team instead of focusing only on tasks. I will also improve my negotiation skills by building more confidence and improving my communication so I can better motivate others.
2. I will improve my estimation skills by using past experiences, breaking projects into smaller tasks, and including extra time to prevent schedule problems.
3. I will help prevent antipatterns like Ultimate Weapon and Kiosk City by encouraging teamwork, sharing knowledge, and documenting important information so everyone understands the system.
4. Finally, I will apply systemic thinking by considering how my decisions affect the entire project and team, not just my individual responsibilities.

Key Takeaways from This Course

- Leadership is not just about managing tasks, but also about motivating and supporting people.
- Accurate estimation is necessary to prevent schedule failure.
- Communication and teamwork are essential for project success.
- Antipatterns can cause serious problems if they are not addressed early.

- Systemic thinking helps project managers understand the bigger picture and make better decisions.